

Men like John W. Gates—a typical Wall Street millionaire of the fiction writer's brand—had to be more than gamblers and had to do more than buy and sell stocks in order to get where they did. Before he blew into Wall Street Gates had earned the reputation of being the best salesman in the United States. He knew how to make nails and pull wire—the genuine article—better than any expert in the business. And having made supplies he knew how to sell them. He was thus no nonentity, no brainless cipher. But his famous offer to “bet you a million” was remembered, while his real achievements in the field of industry were quickly forgotten—if they were ever known—by the public.

*The term “Wall Street” . . . embraces
anything . . . from the get-rich-thievishly
fraternity . . . to the strongest of our financiers
and banking institutions.*

Not one “Wall Street millionaire” of the most criticised pattern will be found devoid of special ability in some direction or other. The self-made ones who stay millionaires are not fools. Few of them are knaves, either.

The trouble is that the crazy exploits of the few besmirch the reputation of the many. And of course when a Wall Street plutocrat runs amuck it makes a spicy front-page story.

In one hour at a Monte Carlo table Charles M. Schwab earned more unpleasant notoriety than years of amazing achievement in steel making could combat. It drove him, in a sense, from the presidency of the greatest industrial organization in the world, the billion-dollar Steel Corporation. Since then he has done bigger things than any other steel worker in the United States, but nine people in ten would, on hearing Schwab's name mentioned, recall the Monte Carlo incident and let the rest pass.